



FOR GOD'S SAKE:
Devotees at
Pataleshwar temple

Swept Up in Faith

Devotees offer brooms to Lord Shiva at Pataleshwar temple to get relief from skin ailments

■ **By Shyamal Yadav**

Lord Shiva is a pan-Hindu god who is worshipped by one and all—gods, human beings and demons—and getting blessed in return. It is not just the god but also the offerings made to please him that are quite fascinating. While the 'destroyer' or Mahesh, as he is commonly known, is often offered things like poisonous fruits and flowers, in the century-old Pataleshwar temple in the small village of Sadatbadi, in Moradabad, his devotees offer him something rather unusual: brooms.

Every Monday, devotees from nearby villages and even faraway places come to offer brooms at this temple of Lord Shiva which is located 6 km away from Bahjoi, a municipal committee on the Moradabad-Agra highway. The brooms offered to the god are always in circulation. Once offered, these brooms are sold by the temple authorities to the shopkeepers sitting outside the complex, from where they are bought again by devotees and offered to the deity.

This temple attracts attention not just for its unique offering but also for the peculiar belief attached to it. People say that offering brooms will ease suffering. According to local lore, if someone who is suffering from any sort of skin



ailment takes an oath to offer broom at this temple, Lord Shiva fulfills his wish and offers a cure. "This is quite true. People come here, offer brooms and get cured," says Kamal Kumar Kamal, who has been visiting this temple for almost 28 years now.

Babu Giri, whose family is in charge of the temple's management, says hundreds of people come here on Mondays, but on special occasions like Shivaratri, people throng this temple and worship Shivlinga by making this unique offering which they think will alleviate them of their sufferings. Another devout follower, Shrikrishna, 50, offers a broom to the god every Monday for his son Neeraj, 15, who has pimples and boils on his body. He says, "I am sure medicine cannot cure my son. I'm dependent on Lord Shiva to heal him." The son's condition is gradually improving and the father insists it is only because of Lord Shiva.

This temple, which was built in 1902, provides a ray of hope to many people suffering from conventionally incurable skin diseases. Medical science may mock this practice, it is faith and trust that makes people throng this temple to seek succour from their ailments. Even as science advances, this undying faith in the benevolence of the divine lives on.